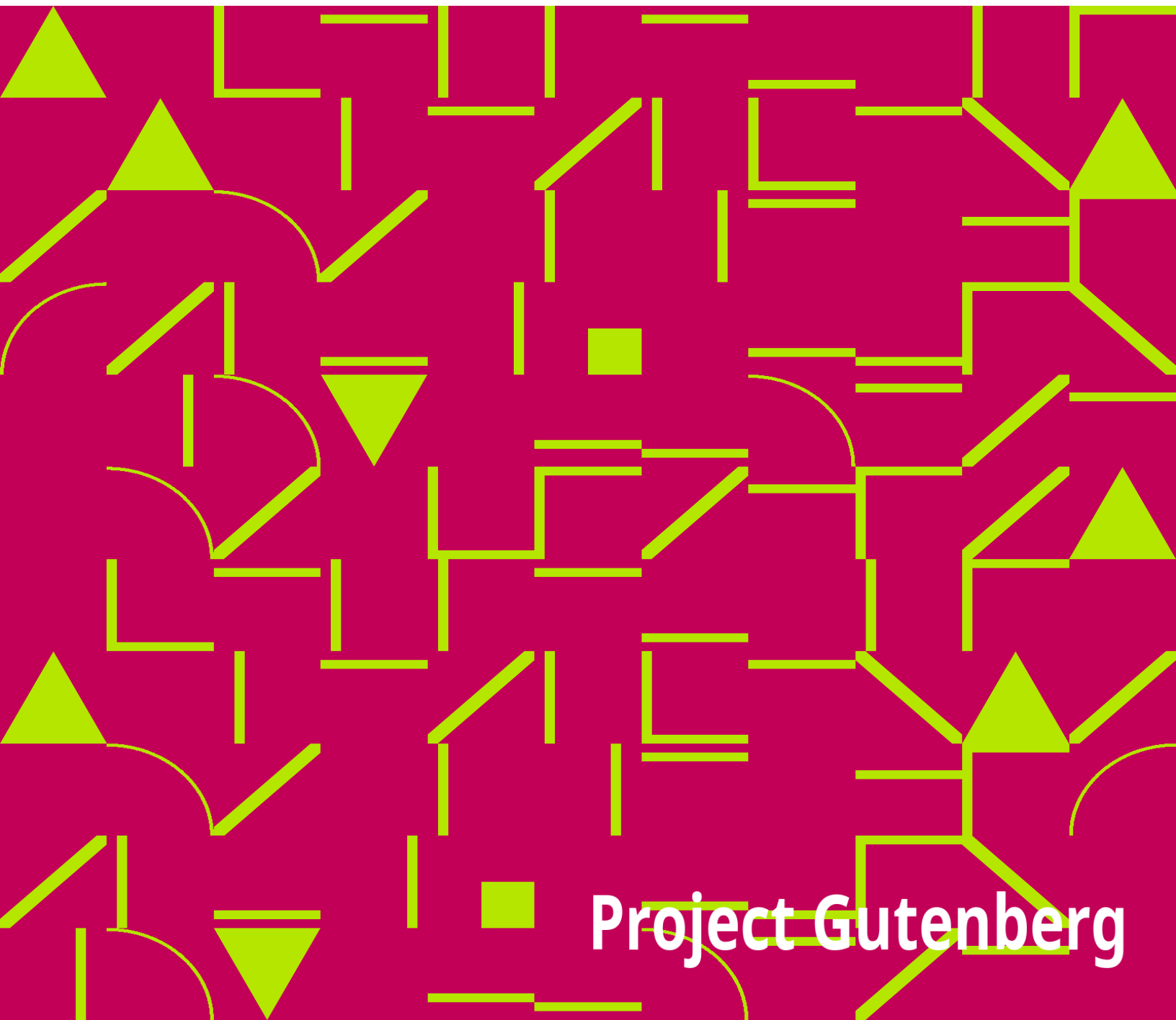


A Letter to a Gentleman in the Country, from His Friend in London

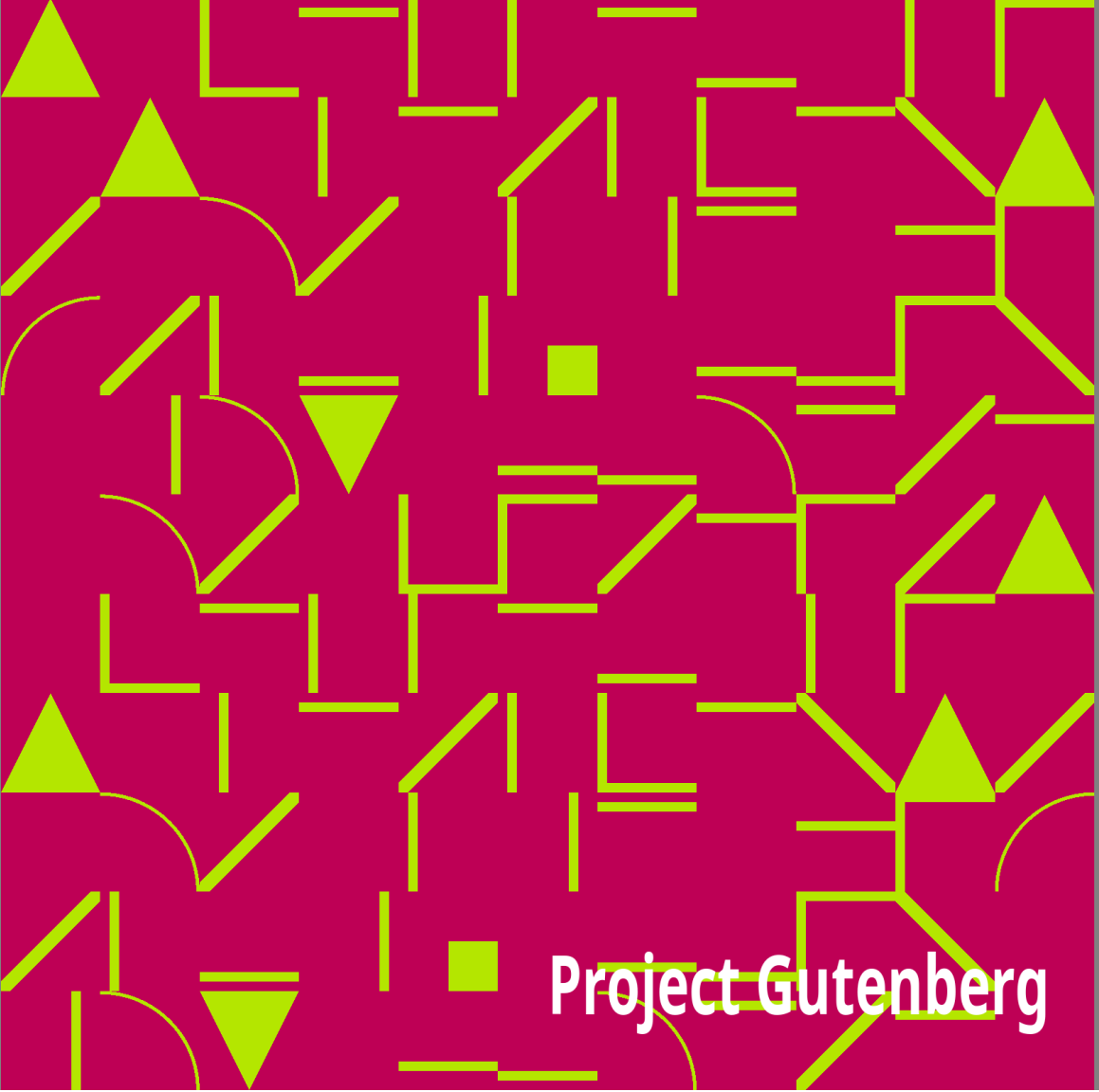
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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK A LETTER TO A
GENTLEMAN IN THE COUNTRY, FROM HIS FRIEND IN LONDON

A

LETTER

TO A

Gentleman in the Country,

FROM

His Friend in LONDON:

Giving an

Authentick and circumstantial Account of
the Confinement, Behaviour, and Death of

ADMIRAL BYNG,

As attested by the Gentlemen who were present.

Mens conscia Recti.

LONDON:

Printed for and sold by J. LACY, the Corner of
St. Martin's-Court, St. Martin's-Lane, near
Leicester-Fields. MDCCLVII.

[Price One Shilling.]

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LETTER

TO A

Gentleman in the Country,

FROM

His Friend in LONDON, &c.

DEAR SIR,

Agreeable to your request, I have taken great pains to collect all the particulars, relating to the behaviour and death of the unfortunate ADMIRAL BYNG.

You know me sufficiently, to be satisfied that I have never had any bias in his favour, or against him. But as the whole affair has been laid before the publick, sufficiently plain for every man of common sense, not prejudiced, to understand it; excepting some *inexplicable* Circumstances relating to the *Court Martial*; I may be allowed to judge for myself, and yield to truths which I think can admit of no farther controversy.

It is true, there are yet *sophisters*, who want to *impose* upon us; but I think their designs are easily seen through. It is impossible that any impartial man should fail to observe the almost incredible pains taken to misrepresent and blacken his publick and private character. Even now, after he has paid the forfeit of his *life*, for *crimes*, at most, only *disputably* so, there are a great number of emissaries, who seem to make it their business to go from one coffee-house to another, spreading the most scandalous reports with regard to his death. *Dying Speeches*, containing the most *infamous absurdities*, have been imposed upon the publick, with several booksellers names prefixed in the title-page, in order to give them the air of authenticity.

For what end and purposes all these measures have been taken, they can best tell, who have always been, and still continue so indefatigably industrious. But I must confess they greatly raise my indignation; and I am at last fully persuaded, *hidden political machinery* has been employed against this unfortunate gentleman. Our friend *D*—— says, *cunning heads, black hearts, and long purses*. Indeed, I think it appears very evident, that some persons are very active and solicitous to *load him* with ignominious crimes, with a view *to exculpate themselves*, or others; to render him odious in the eyes of the people, that his fall may be unlamented. But can a generous nation, like this, where understanding abounds, accept of his blood for the crimes of any other? surely, it cannot be.

I believe you will agree with me in thinking, that the Admiral's behaviour before and at the time of his death; his observations and conversation with his friends; together with the paper containing his thoughts on the occasion, wrote by himself, and signed, which he gave to the Marshal of the Admiralty, immediately before the sentence passed upon him was put in execution; must hereafter be his best APOLOGY, EXCULPATION, and ENCOMIUM; must reflect honour upon his family, and be an *indelible reproach to some of our cotemporaries*; who have practised every *wicked artifice, to deceive and spirit up the people*, and to throw a mist over the whole of this transaction.

Without any farther preamble, I shall proceed to give you a relation of the particulars, as they are ascertained to me, by the concurring testimony of gentlemen who were upon the spot; whose veracity cannot be doubted, and whose authority to vouch them again, may be easily obtained.

As you have critically perused the trial and sentence, I presume you will be pleased with some particulars as far back as the time of passing the sentence.

On *Thursday* the 27th of *January*, when the Admiral was sent for on board the *St. George* to receive his sentence, he declared to some of his friends, that he expected to be reprimanded, and that he possibly might be cashiered; "*because, said he, there must have been several controverted points; the Court Martial has been shut up a long time; and almost all the questions proposed by the Court have tended much more to pick out faults*

in my conduct, than to get at a true state of the circumstances; but I profess, I cannot conceive what they will fix upon."

Soon after he got on board, and was in the cabin upon the quarter-deck, a member of the *Court Martial* came out, and told one of his relations, he had the Court's leave to inform him, they had found the Admiral capitally guilty; in order that he might prepare him to receive the sentence. The gentleman went up to him immediately; but was so surprised, he could not tell how to inform him. The Admiral observing his countenance, said to him, "*What is the matter? Have they broke me?*" The gentleman hesitating in his reply, with some confusion of countenance, he added, "*Well, I understand—If nothing but my Blood will satisfy, let them take it.*" Immediately after this, he was sent for into Court, where he continued to be the only man that did not appear moved, while the sentence was reading by the Judge-advocate; and went ashore afterwards with the same air and composure that he came on board.

A gentleman afterwards endeavoured to give him consolation, by representing to him, that a *sentence without guilt could be no stain*; that it was highly improbable such a sentence would be put in execution, considering the extraordinary circumstances attending it; and that there was the greatest probability of a pardon. He replied, "*What will that signify to me? What satisfaction can I receive from the liberty to crawl a few years longer on the earth, with the infamous load of a Pardon at my back? I despise life upon such terms, and would rather have them take it.*"

The gentleman then remarked to him, that his pardon must proceed from justice rather than mercy; and must be more an acknowledgment of his innocence, than a forgiveness of guilt: with that distinction he seemed better satisfied, and reconciled to the thought.

Some days after the sentence was passed, he was conveyed on board the *Monarque*, and confined in the captain's cabin upon the quarter-deck. And as soon as the warrant for his death arrived at *Portsmouth*, all his friends who came to see him, were obliged to leave him before it was dark, and go on shore. An additional number of marine officers and marines were ordered on board that ship. An officer regularly mounted guard, and a great number of centinels were placed, viz. two upon the fore-castle, one over

each side in the chains, two at the cabin-door, two upon the poop, two in a boat under the ship's stern, and, for some part of the time, two in the stern-gallery; besides a guard-boat constantly rowing round the ship during the night. These centinels had orders to call aloud to each other, *all is well*, every five minutes throughout the night; by which means, almost as soon as the last sentinel had answered, it was time for the first to begin again, and there was a perpetual round of, *all is well*. This circumstance almost totally depriving the Admiral of sleep, because the centinels were mostly close to him where he lay, made him frequently say, "*I did hope for leave to sleep, and apprehend I might be sufficiently guarded and taken care of, without so frequent a repetition of this noisy ceremony close to my ear.*"

At length the lieutenants of the ship had orders to watch in the great cabin, relieving each other every four hours, as is customary at sea: so that there was always one of them in the cabin with him day and night, who delivered up the charge of the Admiral's person to the next officer, keeping a journal, in which was minuted down every person's name who came to him, the time when he came, and the time of his going away; and the order to the centinels for calling out every five minutes, was then omitted.

When captain *Montague* waited upon him, to inform him that the warrant from the Admiralty was come, for putting the sentence passed upon him in execution, he received the news with the same cool composure, that he had received the sentence; without discovering the smallest emotion, depression of spirits, or alteration in his behaviour.

The same gentleman waited upon him again, on the 27th of *February*, being the day before that which was appointed for his execution, and, in Admiral *Boscawen*'s name, acquainted him that a respite was arrived for fourteen days. He composedly desired his compliments to Admiral *Boscawen*, with thanks for his intelligence, without appearing in the smallest degree elevated, or even pleased beyond his usual. His friends, on that occasion, represented to him what had passed in the House of Commons, magnified and dwelt upon every favourable circumstance; and, giving themselves up to joy, congratulated him on the certainty of an honourable pardon, which they imagined must follow. He calmly replied, "*I am glad you think so, because it makes you easy and happy; but I think it is now become an affair*

merely political, without any farther relation to right or wrong, justice or injustice; and therefore I differ in opinion from you."

During all the time of his confinement, his comportment was uniformly the same; almost always chearful, sometimes, with decency, facetious. This gave rise to a rumour that he expected a pardon, or meditated an escape; which was most industriously propagated, to lessen the merit of his behaviour, by the same instruments that had been always made use of to wrest every circumstance to his disadvantage, and asperse him. Some of those *wretches* were employed, during his trial, to send up to town, for the newspapers, *false minutes* of the evidence; and to pick out such passages as could be made to bear a harsh construction, or, by *sophistical* comments, be brought to carry the appearance of *guilt*, in order to inflame the people, already prepossessed by similar practices. The unwary were prejudiced by these arts, and joined in the cry against him; but he defeated the further designs of his enemies, by preserving the same equanimity to the last.

The nearer approach of death made no change in his manner. He had divine service performed in the morning by the chaplain of the *Monarque*, and usually spent the remainder of the day in conversation with his friends; and sometimes in regulating his private family-affairs, when any thing occurred to his memory as not properly settled agreeable to his intention.

On *Saturday* the 12th of *March*, in the evening, when his friends were going on shore as usual, he took leave of his two nephews in a tender manner, and desired they would not come on board to him again, lest any immoderate grief in them should soften him.

On *Sunday* morning captain *Montague*, having received a warrant from Admiral *Boscawen* for his execution next day, gave it to the Marshal to read to him; which he calmly heard read over, and then remarked, with some warmth, that the place appointed by the warrant was upon the fore-castle. "*Is not this,*" said he, addressing himself to his friends, "*putting me upon the footing of a common seaman, condemned to be shot? Is not this an indignity to my birth, to my family, and to my rank in the service? I think I have not been treated like an officer in any instance since I was disgraced, excepting in that of being ordered to be shot.*" He appeared much disturbed at this circumstance, and looked upon it as a considerable grievance. His

friends, fearing it could not be altered, because the warrant was expressly worded so, represented to him, that it appeared to them an impropriety; but they hoped he would think the place immaterial, a circumstance beneath his notice, and not let any such consideration break in upon his tranquillity of mind. He then composed himself again, and replied, *“It is very true, the place or manner is of no great importance to me; but I think living Admirals should consult the dignity of the rank, for their own sakes. I cannot plead a precedent: there is no precedent of an Admiral, or a General Officer in the Army, being shot. They make a precedent of me, such as Admirals hereafter may feel the Effects of.”*

After this he appeared calm again; and in the forenoon heard prayers read by the chaplain of the *Monarque*, and received the sacrament in a very decent devout manner, with some of his relations and friends.

At dinner he was chearful as usual, very politely helped his friends, and drank their healths; but did not sit long at table. In the afternoon he frequently turned the conversation upon the place and manner of his execution next day, at times expressing some uneasiness that the place appointed should be the fore-castle: and perceiving that his friends avoided the subject out of complaisance to him, sometimes telling him they thought it improper, *“I like to talk upon the subject,”* said he: *“It is not to be supposed I do not think of it; why then should it be more improper to talk of it?”*

He frequently observed how the wind was, and wished it might continue westerly long enough for the members of his Court Martial, who were upon the point of sailing, to be present at the time the sentence passed upon him was put in execution.

About six he ordered tea, as usual, for himself and his company; and remarking that his friends took notice of his easy manner and conversation, *“I have observed,”* said he, *“that persons condemned to die, have generally had something to be sorry for, that they have expressed concern for having committed; and though I do not pretend to have been exempt from human frailties, yet it is my consolation to have no remorse for any transaction in my publick character, during the whole series of my long services.”*

One of his friends observed to him, that no man was exempt from human frailties; that what came under that denomination were not crimes cognisable here, or supposed to be so hereafter. He replied, "*I am conscious of no crimes; and am particularly happy in not dying the mean, despicable, ignominious wretch, my enemies would have had the world believe me. I hope I am not supposed so now; the Court Martial has acquitted me of every thing criminal or ignominious.*" One of his friends assured him, that none called or thought him so, but obstinately prejudiced persons, and his enemies, interested to deceive the world still; neither of whom would ever own themselves convinced by reasons: at which he seemed much pleased.

In this manner he passed the day, generally walking about the cabin, as is customary on board a ship, to supply the place of exercise; and retiring for a few minutes into the state-room^[1], sometimes with one friend, sometimes with another, when he had any thing particular to say to them.

In the evening his friends, desirous to be with him a little longer that night than had been permitted before, on purpose to entertain him, and enjoy his conversation for a last time, sent to Admiral *Boscawen*, requesting that indulgence; which was granted for as long as they pleased; but he himself desired they would not exceed the hour of eight, being then about seven: and added, that as they would be so obliging as to pass the evening with him, he must ask them to drink a glass with him. He then ordered a small bowl of punch to be made; and when all were seated round the table, he obligingly helped every one, and taking his own glass with a little punch in it, "*My friends, said he, here is all your healths, and God bless you all: I am pleased to find I have some friends still, notwithstanding my misfortunes.*" When he had drank, and set his glass down, he added, "*I am to die to-morrow; and as my country requires my blood, I am ready to resign it, though I do not as yet know what my crime is. I think my judges, in justice to posterity, to officers who come after us, should have explained my crime a little more, and pointed out the way to avoid falling into the same errors I did. As the sentence and resolutions stand now, I am persuaded no Admiral will be wiser hereafter by them, or know better how to conduct himself on the like occasion.*" Observing one of the company who had his eyes attentively fixed upon him, while he was speaking, "*My friend,*" said he, "*I understand reproof in that grave look. It is a long time since I have spoke so much upon the subject, and you now think I say too much: perhaps I do so.*"

“Far from presuming to mean any reproof,” answered the gentleman, “I am all attention to what you say, Sir; and though all of us here are satisfied of these truths, yet we must be pleased to hear you make them plainer.” “*Be it so,*” replied he; “*but I shall only add one remark more. I am supposed not to have relieved and assisted the van: who then did assist the van, and relieve the three disabled ships, who were upon the brink of being attacked by the body of the enemy? Though the enemy did fire upon them*^[2]*, there is but one witness who says they received damage at that time. May not that one witness be mistaken, who was on board the ship considerably the farthest removed from the enemy of the three, and who had dropt there out of her station, by being disabled before? And why did the enemy bear away from these ships, if it was not because my division was under sail close after them, in a regular line of battle?*”

Here the Admiral stopt; and the conversation for a few minutes turning upon other subjects, he desired to be particularly remembered to several absent friends. The time he appointed for his friends to go ashore drawing near, he got up, and withdrew into the state-room with one of them at a time; and thanking each in a very pathetick manner, for their acts of friendship and services, he embraced them, and took his leave; with intention, as he told them, to spare them the disagreeable and painful office, as his friends, of seeing him next day. But they intreating leave to pay their last respects and services to him in the morning, he consented. One of them observing the Admiral softened into tears upon the occasion, said to him, “Pray, Sir, don’t suffer yourself to be discomposed.” He replied, “*I have not a heart of stone; I am a man, and must feel at parting with my friends; but you will not see me discomposed to-morrow.*” He then dismissed them all, wished them a good night, and desired they would come to him next day at nine; chusing to have the morning to himself.

He carefully avoided desiring any thing himself, that could look like a favour; but one of his relations waited upon Admiral *Boscawen* that evening, and represented to him, that appointing the fore-castle for the place of execution was an indignity to Admiral *Byng*’s rank, and hoped that he would change the place to the quarter-deck. Admiral *Boscawen* said, the order from the admiralty expresly appointed it so; but if it was his request, he would consider of it, and do what lay in his power. The gentleman replied, *I do make it my request, Sir;* and Admiral *Boscawen*, after

considering a little, promised to give directions that the quarter-deck should be the place; which was done accordingly.

When the officers, who watched in the great cabin with the Admiral, relieved each other in the night, the officer who was relieved, always made it a rule, at twelve at night, and at four in the morning, to go into the state-room with the other, to show that the Admiral was there, and deliver over his charge. They seldom found him awake at these hours; but that last night, in particular, they found him both times in a profound sleep.

It was his custom to rise early, and to banter the Marshal for being seldom up so early as him. He was up on *Monday* morning about five; and as soon as he saw the Marshal, about six, “*Well,*” said he, “*Marshal, I think I have beat you at rising this morning.*” Soon after, when he was shifting, as he constantly did every morning betimes, “*Here,*” said he to his valet, “*take these sleeve-buttons, and wear them for my sake; your’s will do to be buried with.*” Having directed that he should be put into his coffin with his cloaths as he died: recollecting himself, he added, “*But hold—as these buttons are gold, my giving them to you may be doubted, and you may be drawn into a scrape.*” Then desired the Marshal, and one of his servants, might be called to witness the exchange.

He spent a considerable part of the morning in the state-room by himself: then came out, and sat down with the Marshal, and breakfasted composedly, as usual. His dress was a plain cloth suit, a light grey mixture, such as he had always wore after he received his order of suspension in *Gibraltar*-bay; having stripped off his uniform, which he immediately threw into the sea, as soon as he had read that order.

At nine, when his friends came on board, in a familiar easy manner, he took each by the hand, and obligingly inquired after their health: and being informed that the quarter-deck was now the place appointed for his execution, in consideration of his rank, he was greatly pleased at it. He then spoke about an erasement in his will, which he had recollected; mentioning the sheet, the number of the line from the top, and the words erased. He expressed some uneasiness at that circumstance, and said, that though he did not apprehend such a circumstance would occasion any dispute amongst his relations, yet believing that erasement not mentioned as is customary

upon the will, he thought it proper something should be drawn up, as an acknowledgment that the erasement was agreeable to his intention; which being done in the manner he desired, he copied it himself, signed it, and desired three gentlemen present to witness it.

After this the Admiral appeared satisfied, as if he had no farther concerns to think of; and had the morning-service performed by the chaplain of the *Monarque*.

The rest of his time was mostly spent in walking across the cabin, conversing sometimes with one friend, sometimes with another. He had always declared that he would die with his face uncovered, and would give the word of command to the platoon of marines himself; saying, "*As it is my fate, I can look at it, and receive it.*"

As the time drew near, his friends unanimously endeavoured to dissuade him from it; frequently half gained his consent to have his face covered, and he as frequently retracted, and said, "*No—it cannot be—I cannot bear it—I must look, and receive my fate.*" But by representing to him, that, considering his rank, it was impossible the marines could receive the word of command from him, or look in his face, and see him looking at them, without being awed and intimidated; by hinting at the consequences which might ensue, that he might be wounded only, and mangled; and by adding every sort of argument and intreaty, he at last was prevailed upon and consented to have a bandage over his eyes, and to make a signal by dropping a handkerchief, though with very great reluctance: "*If it must be so, said he, and you insist, it must be so.*"

He then desired to be made acquainted with all the particulars of the form, that he might make no mistake; telling his friends, that he had never been present at such a ceremony himself. Proposed pulling off his coat; and when one of his friends informed him that was quite unnecessary, "*But, said he, it may be said I kept my coat on as if afraid to receive the blow, or feel the bullets.*" "No," answered the gentleman, "such a remark can never be made; and it must be more decent to make no alteration in dress." "*Well then, replied he, if it is more decent, no alteration shall be made.*"

The commanding officer of the marines was informed of the Admiral's intentions, and the signal he was to make, that he might instruct his men;

and at the same time was desired to let them know they should have a present of ten guineas, to encourage them to behave properly. The marines were all drawn up under arms, upon the poop, along the gang-ways in the waist, and on one side of the quarter-deck. On the other side of the quarter-deck was thrown a heap of saw-dust, and a cushion placed upon it; and in the middle, upon the gratings, a platoon consisting of nine marines were drawn up in three lines, three in each: the two foremost lines, intended to fire, had their bayonets fixed, as is customary on such occasions.

The captains of all the ships in *Portsmouth*-harbour, and at *Spithead*, were ordered to attend with their boats; but lay a-breast upon their oars^[3], without coming on board, to avoid the inconvenience of so great a croud as that would have occasioned.

The Admiral, about eleven, as he walked across the cabin, observed the croud of boats out of one of the side cabin-windows, took his spying-glass and viewed several of them; and perceiving many boats from the shore, as well as the ship-boats, and the decks, shrouds, and yards of all the ships that lay near, covered with men, said he, “*Curiosity is strong—it draws a great number of people together—but their curiosity will be disappointed:—where they are, they may hear, but they cannot see.*”

Perceiving the Marshal had his uniform and sword on, speaking softly to one of his friends, “*Do you observe,*” said he, “*how well dressed the Marshal is?*” “Yes,” answered the gentleman; “I dare say, Sir, he intends paying the last piece of respect to you that he can.” “*I am sensible he means well,*” replied he, “*and I accept the compliment.*” The gentleman added, “To see you so easy and composed, Sir, gives me as much pleasure as I can have on this occasion; but I expected no less from the whole of your conduct heretofore, and the last actions of a man marks his character more than all the others of his life.” “*I am sensible they do, Sir,*” replied he, “*and obliged to you for putting me in mind. I find innocence is the best foundation for firmness of mind.*”

After that, he walked about in the cabin for some time; inquired what time it would be high-water; remarked that the tide would not suit to carry his body ashore after dark; expressed some apprehensions, that his body might be insulted going ashore in the day, on account of the prejudices of the

people: but, on being assured that no such spirit was remaining among the people at *Portsmouth*, he appeared very well satisfied on that head. Then taking a paper out of his pocket, he addressed himself to the Marshal as follows: “*Sir, these are my thoughts on this occasion: I shall give them to you, that you may authenticate them, and prevent any thing spurious being published, that might tend to defame me. I have given a copy to one of my relations.*”

The paper was wrote in his own hand, and contained as follows:

*On board his Majesty’s ship Monarque in Portsmouth-harbour,
March 14, 1757.*

“A few moments will now deliver me from the virulent persecutions, and frustrate the farther malice of my enemies;—nor need I envy them a life subject to the sensations my injuries, and the injustice done me, must create.—Persuaded I am justice will be done to my reputation hereafter.—The manner and cause, of raising and keeping up the popular clamour and prejudice against me, will be seen through.—I shall be considered, (as I now perceive myself) a victim, destined to divert the indignation and resentment of an injured and deluded people, from the proper objects.—My enemies themselves, must, now, think me innocent,—Happy for me at this last moment, that I know my own innocence, and am conscious, that no part of my country’s misfortunes can be owing to me.—I heartily wish the shedding my blood may contribute to the happiness and service of my country;—but cannot resign my just claim to a faithful discharge of my duty, according to the best of my judgment, and the utmost exertion of my ability, for his Majesty’s honour and my country’s service.—I am sorry that my endeavours were not attended with more success, and that the armament under my command proved too weak to succeed, in an expedition of such moment.—Truth has prevailed over calumny and falshood, and justice has wiped off the ignominious stain of my supposed want of personal courage, or disaffection—my heart acquits me of these crimes,—but who can be presumptuously sure of his own judgment?—If my crime is an error in judgment, or differing in opinion from

my judges; and if yet, the error in judgment should be on their side,—God forgive them, as I do; and may, the distress of their minds, and uneasiness of their consciences, which in justice to me they have represented, be relieved, and subside, as my resentment has done.—The supreme Judge sees all hearts and motives, and to him I must submit the Justice of my cause.”

J. BYNG.

Soon after he had so spoke, an officer came to the cabin-door, and in a low voice informed one of his friends the hour of twelve was drawing near. He, overhearing, replied, *“It is very well;”* and retired into the state-room for about three minutes. In the mean time the cabin-doors were thrown open, and the Admiral, opening the state-room-door, came out, with a stately pace and composed countenance: he made a bow to his friends in the cabin, and speaking to the Marshal, *“Come along,”* said he, *“my friend;”* and walked out upon the quarter-deck. Then turning to the Marshal, with an easy bow, he gave him the paper, containing as above, saying, *“Remember, Sir, what I have told you relating to this paper;”* and went to the cushion and kneeled down. One of his friends attended him to the cushion, and offered to tie the bandage over his eyes; but having a white handkerchief ready folded in his hand, he replied, with a smile on his countenance, *“I am obliged to you, Sir—I thank God, I can do it myself—I think I can—I am sure I can;”* and tied it behind his head himself. Then taking the gentleman by the hand, *“God bless you, my friend,”* said he; *“don’t stay longer here; they may shoot you.”* The marines, in the mean time, advanced about two paces, and, as soon as the gentleman retired, presented their pieces; the first line kneeling, their bayonets about half a yard from his breast; the second stooping, and close to the first; the third line standing upright, were appointed a reserve, in case any life should remain after the two first had fired. The Admiral continued upon his knees something more than a minute, appearing very composed, and to be making an ejaculation; and then dropped his handkerchief, the signal agreed upon. The platoon immediately fired; one missed, four passed thorough different parts of his breast, and one through his heart, and he sunk down motionless, gently falling on his side, as if still studious to preserve *decency* and *dignity* in his FALL.

The spectators were amazed at the intrepidity of his behaviour, and scarce could refrain from tears; even the common seamen, one of whom having stood all the while full of attention, with his arms across, cried out, with a kind of enthusiasm, when he saw him fall, *There lies the bravest and best officer of the navy*. The *Ramillies*, the ship he had his flag on board of, breaking loose from her moorings, immediately after his death, induced the people to believe that she sympathized with her Admiral.

His coffins were made at *Portsmouth* two days before, and sent on board early that morning; one of wood inclosed in one of lead, and that again inclosed in another of wood. On that of lead was the following plain inscription:

THE HON. JOHN BYNG, ESQR.
DIED MARCH 14th, 1756.

As soon as his body was cold, it was put into his coffin, and sent on shore to the Dock-yard in the evening; from whence it has been since removed to the family burying-place at *South-Hill* in *Bedfordshire*.

Thus did this *unfortunate* but *undaunted Gentleman*, arrive at a place of rest, whose sentence explained, as an Epitaph, would do him honour; who to the last moment asserted his innocence, and assured us that he has been violently *persecuted* by party rage; treated with many *unprecedented indignities* and *hardships*; *calumniated* and *misrepresented* to the people, who had been prepossessed by the early intrigues of his *enemies*, in order to *screen themselves*; and at last *sacrificed*, to appease the *misguided resentment* of the nation. His fate is now lamented by far the majority of people of understanding, who see through the mist, and are disposed to view him in the same light. Posterity, in spite of slander, will undoubtedly do justice to his injured character and honour. In all probability, the present age will set the example, when our Patriots have unravelled the Mystery.

So much fortitude and firmness of mind, so heroick a manner of dying, under a cloud of prejudices and misfortunes, cannot fail to be the result and clearest demonstration of innocence, and a mind conscious of a proper discharge of its duty.

*I am, Sir,
Yours, &c.*

London, March
25th, 1757.

P. S. I have purposely informed you of several minute particulars, because they have been much the subject of conversation, and very whimsically and maliciously described by the authors of *Pamphlets*, composed of *common Reports* and *Scraps* from *News-papers*.

F I N I S .

Footnotes:

[1] The apartment where the captain sleeps, so called on board a ship.

[2] It does not appear that a single man was killed on board either of these ships, when the enemy passed them.

[3] That is, from time to time, rowing a little, when it is necessary, to keep in the same place.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK A LETTER TO A
GENTLEMAN IN THE COUNTRY, FROM HIS FRIEND IN LONDON

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